

Chapter 18

When Everything Fell Apart

The next morning...

Elara was standing in front of the mirror, getting ready for work.

She had barely slept.

Roman's face kept appearing in her thoughts.

The memory.

His voice.

The words she had forgotten for so long.

Can I get one chance?

She touched her hair absentmindedly.

Then suddenly...

her bedroom door opened.

Her father stood there.

His face looked unusually serious.

"Elara."

She turned.

"What happened?"

"Come downstairs."

"Why?"

"Just come."

Something in his voice made her stop asking questions.

She followed him downstairs.

The television in the living room was already on.

Her mother was standing near the sofa.

The moment Elara looked at the screen...

she froze.

A red banner covered the bottom of the television.

BREAKING NEWS

ETHAN INVOLVED IN LATE-NIGHT FATAL ACCIDENT

The reporter's voice filled the room.

"According to preliminary reports, Ethan Ashford was involved in a serious road accident late last night. Witnesses claim the vehicle was being driven at high speed, and alcohol may have been involved."

Elara stared at the screen.

A damaged car.

Police lights.

Rain-soaked roads.

Ambulances.

Her father's voice came quietly from behind her.

"That's not all."

The screen changed.

Another headline appeared.

THREE-YEAR-OLD NOAH CASE REOPENED

Elara stopped breathing.

"What?"

The reporter continued.

"New evidence connected to the three-year-old death of Noah has surfaced overnight. The evidence appears to contradict the original investigation."

Elara's fingers tightened around the flower pot she had been holding.

The reporter continued.

"The newly released recording allegedly contains a private conversation between Ethan Ashford and his father..."

Her heart began pounding.

Then...

she heard it.

Ethan's voice.

His father's voice.

The words.

The confession.

The cover-up.

Roman.

Her eyes widened.

"No..."

The flower pot slipped from her hands.

It hit the floor.

Crash.

The sound echoed through the room.

The pot shattered.

But Elara barely noticed.

The television continued.

ROMAN ASHFORD CLEARED OF THREE-YEAR-OLD CASE

Her lips trembled.

Roman.

Not guilty.

He hadn't done it.

He had never been the person she believed he was.

Her mother stepped toward her.

"Elara..."

But Elara suddenly turned.

The front door opened at the same moment.

Eva and Daniel rushed inside.

They were both breathless.

"Elara!"

Daniel looked toward the television.

His face fell.

Eva immediately went toward her.

"Please..."

Elara stepped backward.

Her eyes were filled with tears.

"I have to go."

"Where?" Eva asked.

Elara didn't answer.

She turned and ran.

The front door slammed behind her.

She ran down the street.

She didn't know where she was going.

She only knew she couldn't stay there.

Her vision became blurred.

Tears filled her eyes so quickly that the buildings around her turned into shadows.

She wiped her face.

But the tears wouldn't stop.

Roman's face kept appearing in her mind.

The library.

His voice.

The night she had forgotten.

The years she had spent hating him.

"Roman..."

Her voice broke.

"I'm sorry."

She kept running.

Then...

the first drops of rain touched her face.

She didn't stop.

More rain followed.

Within moments, the sky opened.

Cold water ran through her hair.

Her clothes became soaked.

Her breathing grew heavier.

But she kept going.

She couldn't see clearly anymore.

Not because of the rain.

Because she couldn't stop crying.

She slowed.

Her steps became uneven.

Then her foot slipped.

She fell hard onto the wet pavement.
Her hands caught her fall.
She stayed there for a moment.
Rain poured over her.
Then she started crying.
Not quietly.
Not carefully.
She cried like everything she had believed for years had shattered at once.
"I trusted them..."
Her voice shook.
"I hated you..."
She covered her face.
"I thought you did it..."
A sob escaped her.
"I'm sorry..."
She tried to stand.
Her legs trembled.
She took a few steps.
Then stumbled again.
But this time...
she didn't fall.
She kept walking.
Because somewhere inside her heart...
she already knew where she needed to go.

Roman

Across the city...
Roman stood in his apartment, watching the same news coverage.
His investigator stood nearby.
"The recording is everywhere now."
Roman nodded.
"Good."
"Ethan's father is being questioned."

"And Ethan?"

"Police are at the hospital."

Roman looked toward the television.

The footage showed reporters gathering outside the Ashford residence.

Cameras.

Police vehicles.

Questions being shouted.

The man who had spent years protecting his family's reputation...

could no longer control the story.

Roman's phone vibrated.

A message appeared.

We lost sight of Elara.

Roman's expression changed immediately.

"Find her."

"We're trying."

Roman grabbed his jacket.

"I'll handle it."

He left the apartment.

Outside Roman's Apartment

By the time Roman returned...

the rain had become heavier.

He stepped out of the elevator.

Then stopped.

Someone was sitting on the floor outside his door.

Elara.

She was soaked.

Her hair covered part of her face.

Tears were still running down her cheeks.

Roman's expression changed instantly.

"Elara."

She slowly looked up.

For a moment...

she didn't seem to understand where she was.

Roman immediately crouched beside her.

"Hey."

She tried to speak.

Nothing came out.

Roman reached for her hand.

"Look at me."

Her lips trembled.

"You..."

She swallowed.

"You weren't..."

Her voice broke.

Roman didn't make her finish.

"I know."

She suddenly started crying again.

"I believed them..."

"I know."

"I hated you..."

Roman's eyes softened.

"I know."

"I'm sorry."

"You don't have to apologize right now."

Elara shook her head.

"I should have known."

Roman gently held her hand.

"No."

His voice was firm.

"You believed what everyone told you."

He looked at her soaked clothes.

"You're freezing."

Elara tried to stand.

Her knees weakened.

Roman immediately caught her.

"Easy."

She couldn't steady herself.
Without saying anything else, Roman carefully lifted her and carried her inside.
He placed her gently on the sofa.
Then disappeared for a moment.
When he returned...
he had a clean towel and a glass of water.
He handed her the towel first.
"Here."
Elara held it with trembling hands.
Roman crouched in front of her.
"Dry your hair."
She looked at him through tear-filled eyes.
He held out the glass.
"Small sips."
Elara took it.
Her hands were still shaking.
Roman stayed beside her.
"Calm down, Elara."
"Don't cry."
"You've been carrying too much for too long."
She closed her eyes.
A tear slipped down her cheek.
Roman quietly took her hand.
For a while...
neither of them spoke.
Outside...
sirens filled the streets.

Meanwhile

Police vehicles surrounded Ethan's house.
Reporters stood behind the barriers.
Cameras flashed continuously.
The same headlines were being repeated across every news channel.

ETHAN ASHFORD EXPOSED.

POLITICAL FAMILY FACES MAJOR INVESTIGATION.

THREE-YEAR-OLD CASE REOPENED.

And beneath all of them...

one name was finally being cleared.

ROMAN ASHFORD.

But inside Roman's apartment...

Elara sat quietly beneath the warm light.

The rain continued outside.

Her tears had finally slowed.

She looked at Roman.

"I spent years hating you."

Roman didn't look away.

"I know."

"I thought you were the reason Noah died."

"I know."

She swallowed.

"But you weren't."

Roman remained silent.

Elara's voice became smaller.

"I'm sorry."

Roman gently shook his head.

"Just rest."

She looked down at their hands.

Then whispered,

"I remembered something."

Roman's eyes lifted.

"What?"

Elara looked at him.

"That night..."

A pause.

"You asked me for one chance."

Roman went completely still.

The room fell silent.

And for the first time...
neither of them knew what to say next.
Roman stayed quiet.
He could see how exhausted she was.
"Do you remember what I said?"
Elara shook her head.
"Not completely."
Roman nodded slowly.
"Then don't force yourself."
She looked at him.
"But I need to know."
"You will."
His voice was calm.
"But not today".
Elara didn't answer.
Roman picked up the glass of water and handed it to her.
"Take a rest, Elara."
She looked at him.
"I'm here."
For a few seconds...
she simply stared at him.
Then she nodded.
She leaned back against the sofa.
The rain continued tapping against the windows.
The warmth of the apartment slowly replaced the cold she had felt outside.
Elara's eyes became heavier.
She tried to stay awake.
She wanted to ask another question.
But her mind was exhausted.
Her eyes slowly closed.
And without realizing it...
she fell asleep.

A While Later

Elara slowly opened her eyes.

For a moment...

she didn't know where she was.

Then she remembered.

Roman.

The news.

The rain.

Everything came rushing back.

She sat up slowly.

The blanket was around her shoulders.

The apartment was quiet.

Roman wasn't in the living room.

Then she heard something.

A faint sound coming from the kitchen.

Elara stood up.

She followed the sound.

And stopped at the doorway.

Roman was in the kitchen.

His sleeves were rolled up.

He was standing beside the counter, preparing lunch.

Elara stared at him.

For some reason...

the sight felt strangely normal.

Almost peaceful.

Roman noticed her reflection in the glass cabinet.

He turned around.

"You're awake."

Elara nodded.

"What are you doing?"

Roman glanced at the food.

"Cooking."

She looked at him.

"You cook?"

"Sometimes."

A faint smile appeared on his face.

"You should freshen up."

Elara blinked.

"Now?"

"Yes."

He pointed toward the hallway.

"Your clothes are in the bathroom."

She looked at him in surprise.

"My clothes?"

"I didn't think you would want to stay in wet clothes."

He returned to the food.

"There's a towel too."

Elara stood there for a moment.

Then asked quietly,

"How did you..."

"I had someone bring them."

He looked back at her.

"Go."

"Freshen up."

"Lunch will be ready."

Elara nodded slowly.

"Okay."

She turned toward the hallway.

After a few steps...

she stopped.

Then looked back at him.

Roman was already focused on the food again.

For the first time that day...

Elara's heart felt a little lighter.

She quietly walked toward the bathroom.

Behind her...

Roman continued cooking.

Outside...

the rain kept falling.

But inside...

for the first time in a long time...

everything felt calm.